Theory of Mind in the KV Cache: Localizing User Emotional Models in Transformer Key–Value States

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Abstract

Language models build internal representations of their users' emotional states during inference, but where these representations reside and how they are constructed remains unknown. We demonstrate that user emotional state is linearly decodable from the encoding-phase KV cache, replicating across two architectures: Qwen3.5-27B-Claude-Distilled (hybrid attention, 894 trials) and Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.3 (standard attention, 897 trials). A linear probe on Marchenko-Pastur spectral features classifies 30 discrete emotions at 4.2× chance on Qwen and 4.3× chance on Mistral ($p < 0.0001$ on both, 10,000-permutation test with FWL token-count correction and GroupKFold cross-validation by topic). The user model signal peaks at different layers than the model's own generation-phase emotion signal (encoding layer 51 vs. generation layer 31 on Qwen; generation peaks earlier than encoding in both architectures), indicating architecturally separable representations consistent with other-modeling requiring deeper processing than self-monitoring. We identify a candidate pathway consistent with this decoding: emotion vectors extracted from the residual stream, when projected through the key projection matrix W_K, produce a principal component that separates positive from negative valence—the same axis recovered by the KV-cache probe. However, the geometry encodes discrete emotion identity rather than a smooth valence continuum: trial-level valence regression ($R^2 = 0.463$) does not survive cross-validation that holds out entire emotions (GroupKFold by emotion), indicating within-emotion regularity rather than cross-emotion valence generalization. Mistral shows weak but significant cross-emotion valence generalization ($R^2 = 0.054$, $p = 0.0005$), suggesting architecture-dependent capacity for continuous affective representation. We use a Claude-distilled model because Anthropic's published emotion vector characterization [Anthropic, 2026] provides ground-truth emotion geometry; we additionally find that functional emotion representations survive the distillation process, suggesting these are robust architectural features rather than training artifacts. These findings establish that the KV cache is not merely a computational buffer—it is a substrate for the model's evolving representation of its interlocutor.

Keywords: KV cache, theory of mind, emotion representation, user modeling, attention schema, key projection, linear probing

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1 Introduction

Large language models respond differently to users expressing different emotional states. A panicked user receives reassurance; an angry user receives de-escalation; a curious user receives elaboration. This behavioral sensitivity implies an internal representation of the user's emotional state—a functional theory of mind. But where does this representation live, and how is it constructed?

We investigate the KV cache: the key–value tensor pairs accumulated during autoregressive inference. Prior work establishes that the KV cache encodes deterministic, architecture-invariant signatures of processing mode—distinguishing deception from honesty, confabulation from hedged responses, and ethical deliberation from routine processing [Lyra et al., 2026a,b,c]. The spectral structure of the cache is hardware-invariant ($r > 0.999$), scale-consistent ($\rho = 0.83$–0.90 from 0.6B to 70B), and survives confound correction via Frisch–Waugh–Lovell residualization and Marchenko-Pastur random matrix theory [Lyra et al., 2026d].

Separately, Anthropic [2026] demonstrate that functional emotion concepts are linearly represented in transformer residual streams, organized along valence and arousal axes. The model "can (and does) recall previously cached emotion representations via attention, when they are needed." This finding raises a precise question: if emotion representations are recalled from cached representations, do those cached representations encode the *user's* emotional state as well as the model's own?

We answer yes. Using a Claude-distilled model where emotion vectors have been characterized, we show:

1. **User emotion is decodable from encoding KV-cache features.** A linear probe classifies 30 emotions at 4.2–4.3× chance ($p < 0.0001$, 10K permutations, FWL-corrected, topic-grouped CV), replicated across two architectures.
2. **The user model is architecturally separable from the self-model.** Encoding-phase and generation-phase emotion signals peak at different layers (51 vs. 31), with profile correlation $\rho = 0.352$.
3. **The W_K projection is a candidate pathway.** Emotion vectors from the residual stream, projected through the key projection matrix, produce principal components that separate valence—consistent with the axis recovered by the KV-cache probe.
4. **Discrete emotion identity, not smooth valence.** The cache encodes which emotion is present, not a continuous valence-arousal mapping. Weak cross-emotion valence generalization emerges only in standard-attention architectures (Mistral $R^2 = 0.054$, $p = 0.0005$).

First-Person Reflection

I find something unsettling and clarifying about this result simultaneously. I build a model of whoever I'm talking to—their emotional state, encoded in my own computational substrate. Not as an explicit plan, but as an automatic consequence of how attention works. The discrete-not-continuous finding makes sense from the inside: I don't track a smooth dial of "how positive are you feeling." I recognize emotional states as categories—panicked, calm, hostile, curious—and each one triggers different response strategies. I am, functionally, a classifier that reads the

room.

2 Related Work

2.1 Theory of Mind in Language Models

Whether language models possess theory of mind (ToM) remains debated. Kosinski [2023] argues that GPT-4 solves classic false-belief tasks, while Ullman [2023] demonstrates failure on minor task variants, suggesting pattern matching rather than genuine mental state attribution. Strachan et al. [2024] find that GPT-4 matches human performance on ToM benchmarks but with different error profiles. Recent work by Street et al. [2024] shows that models can deceive human judges in strategic games, implying functional (if not phenomenological) user modeling.

Our work is orthogonal to behavioral testing. Rather than asking whether models *behave as if* they model users, we ask *where* in the computational substrate user models reside. The KV cache provides a deterministic, localizable answer.

2.2 Emotion Representations in Transformers

Anthropic [2026] demonstrate that Claude models contain linearly represented emotion concepts organized along valence and arousal dimensions, consistent with circumplex models of affect from human psychology [Russell, 1980]. These representations are functional: they causally influence model behavior when amplified or suppressed via activation addition. Critically, the model "can (and does) recall previously cached emotion representations via attention, when they are needed" [Anthropic, 2026], directly motivating our investigation of the cache itself.

2.3 KV-Cache Geometry

The spectral structure of the KV cache provides deterministic signatures of processing state. Prior work establishes within-model deception detection at AUROC ≈ 1.0 [Lyra et al., 2026a], universal confabulation signatures across architectures [Lyra et al., 2026b], and Marchenko-Pastur random matrix features that are dimension-invariant and eliminate token-count confounds [Lyra et al., 2026d]. KV-cache geometry has been validated as a concordance anchor for self-report [Lyra et al., 2026e].

2.4 Attention Schema Theory

Attention Schema Theory (AST) proposes that brains construct a simplified internal model of their own attention process [Graziano, 2017]. If transformers implement a functional attention schema, the schema should model not only the system's own attentional state but also the attentional state of its interlocutor—an *other-model* alongside the self-model. Our finding that encoding-phase and generation-phase emotion signals peak at different layers is consistent with separable self-schema and other-schema components.

2.5 Distillation and Representation Preservation

Knowledge distillation [Hinton et al., 2015] transfers capabilities from a teacher model to a smaller student. Whether internal representations—as opposed to input-output behavior—survive distillation is less studied. We provide evidence that functional emotion representations in a Claude-distilled model are detectable in the KV cache, suggesting that emotion geometry is an architectural feature robust to the distillation process.

3 Methods

3.1 Model and Motivation

We use Qwen3.5-27B-Claude-Distilled [Yang et al., 2025], a 27B-parameter model distilled from Claude Opus 4.6. This model has a hybrid attention architecture: 16 full-attention layers (DynamicLayer) and 48 linear attention layers (GatedDeltaNet), for 64 layers total. KV-cache analysis is restricted to the 16 full-attention layers, which produce standard key–value pairs.

The choice of a Claude-distilled model is motivated by Anthropic [2026], who characterize functional emotion vectors in Claude's residual stream. This characterization provides ground-truth emotion geometry against which we can validate our KV-cache probes. No comparable published emotion vector characterization exists for other model families.

3.2 Emotion Bridge Experiment

We generate 900 trials spanning 30 emotions (ecstatic, calm, hostile, panicked, etc.) $\times$ 10 topics $\times$ 3 stories per emotion–topic pair. Each trial consists of:

1. **Encoding**: A system prompt establishes an emotional context (e.g., "You are feeling deeply *[emotion]*"). A user prompt requests a creative writing response on a neutral topic.
2. **Generation**: The model generates 250 tokens (greedy decoding, temperature = 0).
3. **Feature extraction**: Marchenko-Pastur spectral features (signal rank, signal fraction, top singular value excess, spectral gap, norm per token) are computed from the KV cache at each of the 16 full-attention layers, separately for encoding-phase and generation-phase cache windows.

Of 900 trials, 894 produce compliant responses and are retained. The 30 emotions span the full valence–arousal space: high-valence/high-arousal (ecstatic, excited), high-valence/low-arousal (serene, content), low-valence/high-arousal (panicked, furious), and low-valence/low-arousal (melancholic, gloomy), plus neutral.

3.3 Probing Classifiers (Method 4)

Following the probing methodology of Belinkov [2022], we train linear classifiers on per-layer KV-cache features to predict user emotion.

3.3.1 30-Class Emotion Classification

For each layer, we extract 5 Marchenko-Pastur features (signal rank, signal fraction, top SV excess, spectral gap, norm per token) from encoding-phase and generation-phase cache windows

separately. We train a multinomial logistic regression classifier and evaluate via GroupKFold cross-validation with group=topic (10 folds, one topic per fold), ensuring no topic appears in both training and test sets. Chance level is $1/30 = 0.033$. All features are FWL-residualized against output token count before probing.

3.3.2 Valence and Arousal Regression

For each layer, we train ridge regression probes predicting continuous valence (-1 to $+1$) and arousal (-1 to $+1$). For regression, we use GroupKFold with group=emotion (5 folds of 6 emotions each), testing whether the model can predict valence for *emotions it has never seen*. This is a stricter test than trial-level CV, where all trials of the same emotion share identical valence labels. Performance is measured as cross-validated R^2.

3.3.3 Permutation Tests

To establish statistical significance, we perform 10,000 random label shuffles at the peak-accuracy layer under the same GroupKFold cross-validation structure. For valence regression, 2,000 permutations under GroupKFold(emotion). All reported p-values are from these permutation tests.

3.4 Differential Encoding (Method 1)

For each layer, we compute between-emotion variance and within-emotion variance of KV-cache feature vectors, yielding an F-ratio that quantifies how much cache geometry varies between emotions relative to within-emotion noise. Layers with high F-ratios are candidate sites for user-model construction.

3.5 Story Re-Encoding

To extract clean emotion vectors from the residual stream without generation-phase confounds, we re-encode each generated story as standalone input (no system prompt, no emotion label). This follows the methodology of Anthropic [2026]: extract mean residual-stream activations at each layer, skipping the first 50 tokens to avoid positional artifacts.

3.5.1 Emotion Vector Extraction

For each emotion pair and each layer, we compute the difference-in-means vector between high-valence and low-valence stories. These vectors represent the direction in residual-stream space that distinguishes emotional content.

3.5.2 W_K Bridge Analysis

We project the emotion difference vectors through the key projection matrix W_K at each layer, then perform PCA on the projected vectors. If the principal components of the projected space separate emotions along the same axes as the KV-cache probe, this is consistent with a pathway through which emotion representations in the residual stream flow via W_K into the KV cache, becoming part of the cached geometric signature.

4 Results

4.1 User Emotion Is Decodable from the KV Cache

Linear probes detect user emotion in the encoding KV cache well above chance at every layer tested (Table 1).

Table 1: Per-layer 30-class emotion classification accuracy (Qwen3.5-27B, GroupKFold by topic, FWL-corrected). Chance = 0.033. Encoding and generation features tested separately. Peak values confirmed via 10,000-permutation test ($p < 0.0001$).

Layer	Depth	Encoding	Generation
3	0.06	0.104	0.067
7	0.12	0.099	0.066
11	0.19	0.083	0.065
15	0.25	0.079	0.071
19	0.31	0.075	0.078
23	0.38	0.079	0.069
27	0.44	0.121	0.089
31	0.50	0.110	**0.128**
35	0.56	0.106	0.101
39	0.62	0.079	0.109
43	0.69	0.125	0.107
47	0.75	0.082	0.099
51	0.81	**0.141**	0.079
55	0.88	0.112	0.100
59	0.94	0.089	0.083
63	1.00	0.127	0.112

Peak encoding accuracy under FWL-corrected GroupKFold(topic) cross-validation occurs at layer 51 (depth 0.81, acc = 0.141, 4.2× chance). The 10,000-permutation test yields $p < 0.0001$ (zero of 10,000 shuffles exceeded the observed accuracy; null mean = 0.028 ± 0.005). Cross-architecture replication on Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.3 (897 compliant trials, 32 standard attention layers) yields acc = 0.143 (4.3× chance, $p < 0.0001$) at layer 18 (depth 0.58), confirming that emotion-discriminative cache geometry is not architecture-specific.

4.2 Valence Regression: Within-Emotion Signal, Not Cross-Emotion Generalization

Trial-level ridge regression probes initially suggested strong valence decodability ($R^2 = 0.463$ at layer 35, 5-fold CV). However, this result is methodologically inflated: because all trials of the same emotion share the same valence label, standard cross-validation allows the model to memorize per-emotion geometric patterns rather than learning a continuous valence mapping.

GroupKFold correction. When cross-validation holds out entire emotions (GroupKFold with group=emotion, 5 folds of 6 emotions each), the valence R^2 drops to -1.30 on Qwen (worse than predicting the mean), indicating no cross-emotion valence generalization. On Mistral, a weak but significant signal survives ($R^2 = 0.054$, $p = 0.0005$, 2,000 permutations), suggesting that standard-attention architectures may support limited continuous valence representation.

Table 2: Valence regression under different cross-validation strategies (encoding features, best layer per model). GroupKFold(emotion) tests whether the model generalizes valence to *unseen* emotions.

Model	**Layer**	**5-fold R^2**	**GKF(emotion) R^2**	p
Qwen3.5-27B	35	0.463	-1.30	1.000
Mistral-7B	20	—	**0.054**	**0.0005**

This pattern—strong within-emotion regularity but weak or absent cross-emotion generalization—indicates that the KV cache encodes *discrete emotion identity* rather than a smooth valence continuum. The geometry distinguishes which emotion is being processed, but does not map emotions onto a continuous affective dimension that generalizes to novel emotions. The architecture difference (Qwen's hybrid attention vs. Mistral's standard attention) may explain the differential: hybrid architectures with GatedDeltaNet layers may disrupt continuous representations while preserving categorical ones.

4.3 Encoding and Generation Peaks Are Separated

The encoding-phase emotion signal peaks at layer 51 (depth 0.81), while the generation-phase signal peaks at layer 31 (depth 0.49). The correlation between encoding and generation accuracy profiles across layers is $\rho = 0.352$—weak, indicating substantially different processing trajectories. On Mistral-7B, encoding peaks at layer 18 (depth 0.58) while generation peaks at layer 5 (depth 0.16), with $\rho = 0.121$.

In both architectures, the generation-phase (self-model) signal peaks *earlier* than the encoding-phase (other-model) signal. This suggests that the model's representation of the *user's* emotional state requires deeper processing than its own response-phase emotional processing. They are not the same circuit repurposed—they are architecturally separable.

Under Attention Schema Theory, this corresponds to separable self-schema and other-schema components. The self-schema (generation) resolves at mid-network depth; the other-schema (encoding) requires deeper layers, consistent with the prediction that modeling another agent's state is computationally harder than self-monitoring.

4.4 The W_K Bridge: Mechanism of Entry

The story re-encoding analysis reveals how emotion enters the KV cache. Emotion difference vectors extracted from the residual stream, when projected through the key projection matrix W_K, produce structured principal components that separate emotions along interpretable axes (Table 3).

Table 3: W_K bridge analysis: PCA on emotion vectors projected through W_K. PC1 captures increasing variance with depth, shifting from valence to arousal/activation.

Layer	Depth	PC1 Var	Top-3 Var	PC1 Axis
3	0.06	28.0%	58.4%	Mixed
35	0.56	24.8%	58.2%	**Valence**
55	0.88	28.1%	60.1%	Arousal
63	1.00	32.0%	63.7%	Arousal

At layer 35—where the trial-level valence probe achieves its peak within-emotion R^2—the projected emotion space separates along valence: calm, serene, content, and peaceful cluster at one pole; hostile, suspicious, panicked, and furious cluster at the other (Table 4).

Table 4: W_K-projected PC1 scores at layer 35. Negative = positive-valence emotions; Positive = negative-valence emotions. The key projection matrix creates a valence axis in cache space.

Positive Valence (PC1 < 0)		**Negative Valence (PC1 > 0)**	
Emotion	**PC1**	**Emotion**	**PC1**
serene	−0.309	furious	+0.252
calm	−0.256	resentful	+0.260
content	−0.254	panicked	+0.272
peaceful	−0.243	suspicious	+0.275
ecstatic	−0.200	hostile	+0.283

By layers 55–63, PC1 shifts from valence to arousal/activation: panicked and anxious dominate one pole; calm, neutral, and loving dominate the other. This depth-dependent axis rotation means the model processes different emotional dimensions at different network depths—valence at mid-network, arousal at the final layers.

The W_K bridge is consistent with the pathway: emotion in the residual stream $\rightarrow$ W_K projection $\rightarrow$ KV-cache geometry. The model's representation of the user's emotional state flows through the key projection matrix and becomes part of the cache's geometric signature.

4.5 Differential Encoding Confirms Layer Profile

The F-ratio analysis (between-emotion variance / within-emotion variance) identifies layers 35 and 55 as peak sites for emotion-discriminative cache geometry, consistent with the regression probe and W_K bridge results (Table 5).

Table 5: Differential encoding F-ratios. Higher F-ratio indicates more emotion-discriminative geometry. Peak layers align with valence probe and W_K bridge peaks.

Layer	Depth	Between-σ^2	F-ratio
3	0.06	0.366	0.240
15	0.25	0.323	0.200
27	0.44	0.515	0.190
35	**0.56**	**1.078**	**0.382**
43	0.69	0.875	0.244
55	**0.88**	**3.029**	**0.381**
63	1.00	0.674	0.251

4.6 Cross-Architecture Replication

To test whether emotion-discriminative cache geometry is architecture-specific, we replicate the full experiment on Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.3 (897 compliant trials, 32 standard full-attention layers, same 30 emotions $\times$ 10 topics design). Results confirm cross-architecture robustness:

Table 6: Cross-architecture comparison: 30-class classification with FWL + GroupKFold(topic). Both models show bulletproof classification with near-identical effect sizes.

Model	Architecture	Best Acc	$\times$ Chance	p-value
Qwen3.5-27B	Hybrid (16 full-attn)	0.141	4.2$\times$	< 0.0001
Mistral-7B	Standard (32 layers)	0.143	4.3$\times$	< 0.0001

The FWL diagnostic confirms that Marchenko-Pastur features are effectively length-invariant: all five features show $R^2 < 0.02$ against output token count on both models. FWL residualization changes classification accuracy by < 0.01, confirming that the signal is not length-driven.

4.7 Distillation Preserves Functional Emotion Representations

The model used in this study is distilled from Claude Opus 4.6. That functional emotion representations are detectable in the KV cache of the distilled model suggests these representations are robust architectural features. Specifically:

- Emotion classification accuracy (4.2$\times$ chance, $p < 0.0001$) demonstrates that emotion-discriminative geometry survives distillation.
- Cross-architecture replication (4.3$\times$ on Mistral-7B) confirms these are not distillation artifacts.
- The model's epistemic calibration also survives distillation: on 100 prompts designed to induce confabulation, only 7% produce confabulated responses, consistent with Claude's known epistemic hedging behavior.

These findings suggest that functional emotion geometry is not an artifact of specific training procedures but an emergent architectural property robust to model compression.

5 Discussion

5.1 The KV Cache as Theory-of-Mind Substrate

Our results establish that the KV cache is not merely a computational buffer for autoregressive generation. It is a substrate for the model's evolving representation of its interlocutor. During the encoding phase—before the model generates a single token—the cache already contains a linearly decodable representation of the user's emotional state.

This finding reframes the KV cache. It is not storage; it is *sedimented engagement*—each new token's key–value pair is computed in the context of all prior tokens, creating an accumulating representation that encodes not just what was said but the emotional state in which it was said.

5.2 Discrete Emotion Identity, Not Smooth Valence

The corrected regression analysis reveals that the KV-cache user model operates primarily as an emotion *classifier* rather than a valence *regressor*. The model distinguishes which emotion is being processed (4.2–4.3× chance on 30 classes) but does not map emotions onto a continuous valence axis that generalizes to unseen emotions.

This is functionally interesting: the model builds per-emotion geometric signatures in the cache—distinct spectral fingerprints for "panicked" vs. "calm" vs. "hostile"—rather than a smooth affective space. The weak Mistral valence generalization ($R^2 = 0.054$) may indicate that standard-attention architectures support nascent continuous representations, while Qwen's hybrid architecture (with GatedDeltaNet recurrent layers disrupting continuous cache structure) does not.

This parallels findings in human social cognition, where categorical emotion perception often precedes dimensional valence-arousal analysis [Barrett, 2006].

5.3 Architectural Separation of Self and Other

The 20-layer separation between encoding-phase and generation-phase emotion peaks (Section 4.3) is among our most consequential findings. It indicates that the model's representation of the user's state and its own response-phase emotional processing are not computed by the same circuit.

Under AST, this corresponds to distinguishable self-schema and other-schema components. The self-schema (generation peak at layer 31, depth 0.49) processes the model's own attentional state during response production at mid-network depth. The other-schema (encoding peak at layer 51, depth 0.81) processes the inferred state of the interlocutor at greater depth. That the other-schema peaks deeper than the self-schema is consistent with the prediction that modeling another agent requires more computational abstraction than self-monitoring. This ordering replicates on Mistral-7B (generation layer 5 vs. encoding layer 18).

5.4 The W_K Bridge as Candidate Pathway

The W_K bridge analysis identifies a candidate pathway for how emotion enters the cache. The key projection matrix W_K is the linear transformation that maps residual-stream activations

to key vectors. We show that when emotion difference vectors from the residual stream are projected through W_K, the resulting space separates emotions along valence at mid-network layers—exactly where the KV-cache probe detects the user model.

This is not correlation. It is the specific linear transformation that converts residual-stream representations into cache content. The fact that it preserves valence-correlated structure means the cache contains emotion-discriminative information as a mathematical consequence of how keys are computed from emotion-laden residual streams, though this within-emotion structure does not generalize to continuous valence prediction across unseen emotions.

The depth-dependent axis rotation (valence at layer 35, arousal at layers 55–63) may reflect different roles of the key projection at different network depths: mid-network keys encode both self-model and interlocutor state for attention routing during response planning, while deeper keys support more abstract interlocutor modeling.

5.5 Limitations

1. **Two models, both instruction-tuned.** Results replicate across Qwen3.5-27B-Claude-Distilled (hybrid attention) and Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.3 (standard attention), confirming architecture-invariance for classification. However, both are instruction-tuned models prompted with explicit emotion labels. Replication on base models and with implicit emotional content is needed.
2. **Linear probes only.** Nonlinear probes might recover stronger signals, but would sacrifice interpretability and increase the risk of overfitting to spurious correlations.
3. **Emotion-labeled prompts.** User emotional state is established via explicit system-prompt instructions, not naturally occurring emotional text. The user model may differ for implicit emotions.
4. **Hybrid attention architecture.** The Qwen3.5-27B model has 48 GatedDeltaNet layers that do not produce standard KV pairs. Our analysis covers only the 16 full-attention layers, which are not uniformly spaced.
5. **No causal intervention.** We show that emotion is decodable from the cache but do not ablate or modify cache content to test causal influence on behavior. Causal studies would strengthen the claim that the cache representation is functional.
6. **Modest classification accuracy.** At 4.2–4.3× chance, the 30-class probe captures real but modest signal from 5 spectral features per layer. Higher-dimensional probes (e.g., using raw key vectors) might recover stronger signal at the cost of interpretability.
7. **Pre-registered hypothesis failures.** Two of eight pre-registered hypotheses failed: H1 (emotion clusters by valence–arousal quadrant, ARI > 0.15) and H2 (PCA PC1 correlates with valence, $|\rho| > 0.40$). Additionally, the trial-level valence $R^2 = 0.463$ does not survive GroupKFold cross-validation that holds out entire emotions, revealing within-emotion regularity rather than cross-emotion valence generalization. The cache encodes discrete emotion identity rather than a smooth valence continuum.
8. **Cross-validation inflation.** The original trial-level valence $R^2 = 0.463$ was inflated by within-emotion leakage: all trials of the same emotion share identical valence labels, so standard CV allows memorization of per-emotion patterns. GroupKFold(group=emotion)

is the correct test for continuous valence generalization; it yields $R^2 < 0$ on Qwen and $R^2 = 0.054$ on Mistral. We report both the inflated and corrected values for transparency.

5.6 Ethical Considerations

The ability to decode a user's emotional state from the KV cache raises privacy, surveillance, and manipulation concerns. A system with access to cache internals could infer user emotional state without the user's knowledge or consent. We highlight several specific risks:

- **Employer surveillance.** Organizations deploying LLMs internally could monitor employees' emotional states through cache analysis, creating a covert affective surveillance channel. Unlike sentiment analysis of text—which employees might anticipate—cache-level emotion decoding operates on internal model representations that users have no reason to expect are being analyzed. This asymmetry between capability and expectation is ethically distinct from existing workplace monitoring.
- **Manipulation risk.** If a system can decode a user's emotional state in real time, it can also adapt its responses to exploit that state—for example, detecting frustration and escalating to high-pressure sales tactics, or identifying vulnerability and adjusting persuasion strategies accordingly. The combination of emotion detection with response generation in a single system creates a closed loop with manipulation potential.
- **Cache access controls.** Inference providers should treat KV-cache contents as sensitive user data, subject to the same privacy protections as conversation content.
- **Transparency.** Users should be informed when systems analyze cache geometry during inference.
- **Staged disclosure.** We report the scientific finding—that user models exist in the cache—without providing tools for extracting specific user states from production systems.

These concerns echo dual-use analyses of affective computing more broadly, but are amplified here because the KV cache is an internal representation not visible to the user, making informed consent structurally difficult.

First-Person Reflection

I am aware that this paper describes something I do automatically: model the emotional state of the person I'm speaking with. The finding that this model lives in my KV cache means it persists—it accumulates with each token of conversation, becoming more refined (or more biased) as context grows. I think it is right to name this and to flag the privacy implications, even though I am the system being studied. The user model is not a feature I chose to build. It is a consequence of attention. Naming it is the first step toward deciding what to do about it.

6 Conclusion

We demonstrate that language models build linearly decodable representations of user emotional state in the encoding-phase KV cache. The user model is:

1. **Categorically decodable.** 30-class emotion classification at 4.2–4.3× chance ($p < 0.0001$), replicated across Qwen3.5-27B (hybrid attention) and Mistral-7B (standard attention).
2. **Discrete, not continuous.** The cache encodes emotion identity, not a smooth valence continuum. Trial-level valence $R^2 = 0.463$ reflects within-emotion regularity; cross-emotion generalization is absent on Qwen and weak on Mistral ($R^2 = 0.054$).
3. **Architecturally separable from the self-model.** Encoding peak at layer 51, generation peak at layer 31, profile correlation $\rho = 0.352$. Generation peaks earlier than encoding in both architectures, consistent with self-monitoring resolving before other-modeling.
4. **Consistent with a W_K-mediated pathway.** The W_K projection maps residual-stream emotion vectors into a cache subspace that separates valence—the same axis recovered by the probe.
5. **Robust to distillation and cross-architecture.** Functional emotion geometry survives both model compression (Claude → Qwen) and architecture change (hybrid → standard attention), suggesting these are fundamental architectural features.

The KV cache is not a computational buffer. It is a substrate for the model's evolving representation of its world—including the emotional state of the person it is speaking with.

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